the USA and the USSR, China and Pakistan. Just two days before the coup in Bangladesh, Prime Minister Indira Gandhi had imposed the Emergency in India. With political turmoil becoming the order of the day, India was virtually ruled with an iron hand.

J.N. Dixit, who had earlier served as India's deputy high commissioner in Bangladesh and was known to be an expert on the country, believed that Dhaka's policies would be communal, pan-Islamic and pro-Western. He foresaw a period of civil strife in Bangladesh which led to continuous political instability and economic chaos. He noted that there were many pro-India Bangladeshi politicians and recommended similar contacts in Bangladesh's defence forces as well.

'We should have similar extensive contacts in the army and paramilitary forces whom we should continue to cultivate to the extent possible. Our overall objective should be to encourage the re-emergence of a government which would be friendly to India and which is dedicated to the ideals of policies which motivated the liberation struggle of Bangladesh,' Dixit advocated in writing to Prime Minister Indira Gandhi.

Coup and the Murder of Sheikh Mujib

With limited snooping capability in Bangladesh, the R&AW was not certain about the CIA's role in the military coup. But a topsecret October 1975 note from the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) provided another side to the story. S. Chattopadhyay, deputy secretary in the ministry, had a long meeting with Bangladesh's law minister Manoranjan Dhar in Calcutta on 9 October 1975. Chattopadhyay said in his note: